The Effects of Forced Displacement on Conviction Rates: Evidence from the Tennessee Valley Authority

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Abstract

I examine the impact of conviction rates on people who received the influx of relocatees from the Tennessee Valley Authority's dam construction projects in the 1930s. I use a Poisson difference-in-differences framework to compare conviction rates of those receiving the influx of relocatees to those who would have if the dam construction would have continued downriver. I find that areas in Alabama receiving a sudden influx of migrants experienced an increase in conviction rates compared to those who didn't. Conviction rates are not significantly different for Black and White people.

1. Introduction

The impact of forced displacement encompasses multiple avenues. It can have crucial impacts on the actual people it displaced (Nakamura and Steinsson, 2022; Harris and Van Leeuwen, 2024) while also generating varied effects on the people and areas that experience the sudden influx in migration (Calderón and Ibáñez, 2016; Dadush and Niebuhr, 2016). Regarding the latter, Verme and Schuettler (2021) argue that forced displacement results in two types of shocks: population shock and public expenditure shock. Such shocks could affect the host community financially, culturally, and socially. One particular area that force migration can affect the host community is through crime. A sudden inflow of migrants can cause changes in the nature of the host area's criminal patterns, though its polarity can vary.

In this paper, I utilize a natural experiment of migration flow from the Tennessee Valley Authority's (TVA) relocation program on the host area's conviction rates. This migration flow is a form of forced displacement from TVA's dam construction projects, displacing residents in its path of construction. Displaced residents were relocated nearby, often within the same counties. To measure the impact of displacement on areas receiving an influx of relocatees, I use a Poisson Difference-in-Differences framework to analyze the change in conviction rates by comparing people receiving the influx of migrants to people living in downriver that would have received an influx of migrants had the dam construction projects continued downriver of the Tennessee River. I find that conviction rates, per 1000 people, for the impacted areas increased by an incident rate of 1.32 times more than the non-impacted areas. When looking at impacts by race, I find a higher incident rate of 1.55 times more convictions for Black people in impacted versus non impacted areas than an incident rate of 1.33 times more convictions for White people in impacted versus non impacted areas; these results, however, are not significantly different from each other. My results suggest that a sudden influx of people in an area can increase crime.

I add to the literature on forced migration by studying the impacts of the TVA's relocation program on host areas. Particularly, forced migration can have significant impacts on its host communities. Kreibaum (2016) finds long-term impacts of refugees on Uganda's local population. Overall, there were positive effects on the consumption of households, given the high demand in the labor market due to the influx of refugees. However, the influx of refugees created negative views from the locals of Ugandans on their own economic standing and their central government, creating a counteracting influence. Kürschner and Kvasnicka (2018) finds the effects of civil war refugees from the Syrian Arab Republic and from ISIS's coup of the region led to an decrease in the average rental price growth in Germany, hence hindering business for landlords. The impacts of forced migration studied in these papers relate to socioeconomic and housing outcomes; I consider effects of demand and supply changes from a crime stance.

I contribute to the crime literature by examining how a change in conviction rates from a sudden increase in population. Two other papers have studied the effect of migrants on crime. Saldarriaga et. al (2024) examines the impact of internal forced displacement[1] on Columbia crime rates. They find evidence of differences in the spatial distribution of crime, specifically, an increase in homicide, personal injuries, and residential burglary rates from an allocation of forcibly displaced persons in densely populated areas.In contrast, Bell and Machin (2011) examines migration to the UK from both migrants from the A8 accession countries and migrants that arrived under a work permit post 2008, and finds no significant effects on violent crimes, and a fall in property crime. They also found migrants were less likely to report victimization than natives. Both articles focus on migration effects on account of better opportunity, whether it be seeking safety or job opportunity. In this paper, I focus on involuntary migration from an exogenous shock in which migrants had no initial motive to relocate.

This paper serves as an extension to Harris and Van Leeuwen (2024) as they examine the socioeconomic effects of forced displacement from TVA's dam construction projects. They found that forced displacement improved labor market outcomes, specifically increasing labor force participation and employment. However, the increase in employment was specifically into unskilled occupations, more so for Black people than White. While their paper looks at the effects on those displaced, this paper considers what happens to the people and area receiving the influx of relocatees. Therefore, I add to the scarce economic literature on the Tennessee Valley Authority. The literature generally finds positive impacts from the TVA. Kline and Moretti (2014) found the TVA sped the industrialization of the Tennessee Valley, creating a large increase in manufacturing employment in TVA counties compared to non-TVA counties. With the Tennessee Valley Authority Act of 1933 being a part of the 'New Deal' programs in the 1930s that utilized relief spending, its impacts may be included in the results of Fishback et. al (2010). They found that a 10% increase in relief spending during the 1930s led to a 1.5% decline in property crime. In my paper, I will further test TVA's positive impact on crime rates specifically to the host regions of displaced individuals.

2. Background: Tennessee Valley Authority's Relocation Program

Following the Great Depression, 'New Deal' programs were created by President Franklin D. Roosevelt to help Americans recover from the economic crisis. One of the biggest programs to come from the New Deal was the Tennessee Valley Act of 1933. This act pioneered the organization known as Tennessee Valley Authority (TVA) whose duties included improving the navigability of the Tennessee River and bringing electrification to the region. The TVA constructed dams throughout the seven states in their jurisdiction, located in the southeastern

[1] Internal forced displacement refers to an involuntary displacement of people within their own country, resulting from a negative force such as conflict or natural disasters (Commission of Human Rights, 1998).

region of the United States. These dam construction projects expanded the Tennessee River, which displaced residents in its pathway.

Knowing their projects would displace residents, the TVA created a relocation program. They sent interviewers to each of the family's homes who were in the path of construction and gathered detailed information on the family and their homes. An appraiser was also sent to the homes to access the value and quality of its structure and land. Once information on the household was obtained, the TVA found nearby homes and lands for sale, appraised them, and relocated residents to homes that were similar to their previous houses. It is important to note that the TVA did not provide compensation for relocation, only their resources in finding similar places for people to relocate to.[2] The TVA relocated the majority of the residents within the same counties as their previous residence.

For the state of Alabama, two main dams were built under the Tennessee Valley Authority Act of 1933: Wheeler dam and Guntersville dam. Construction of Wheeler dam began in 1933 and construction of Guntersville dam began in 1935. Relocation for residents in the path of these projects began in its corresponding start years.

3. Data

3.1 Conviction Records

I obtain conviction records from the 'Alabama, U.S., Convict Records, 1886-1952' provided by ancestry.com. This database provides historical information on people in the Alabama state prison system between 1886 and 1952. The details in these records include the name of the person declared guilty of a criminal offense, their race, gender, age, and birth year, the county they were convicted in, and the date they were sentenced. I specifically collected convict records for counties receiving the influx of relocatees from TVA's dam construction projects (specified from Harris and Van Leewen, 2024)[3] and for the counties in our comparison groups that did not receive an influx of relocatees (discussed in section 4).

3.2 Census Records

After collecting conviction data, I utilized the IPUMS Census lab to link this data to the 1930s census using full name, gender, current county, race, and birth year. This process allows me to identify those convicted from the Alabama Convict records in the Census and hence, identify people in the Census who were not convicted.

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[2] Compensation from the government was granted through appraisals for those who owned their land including owners and landlords.

[3] Harris and Van Leeuwen (2024) identified individuals who were forced to relocate from TVA relocation records provided by ancestry.com. They linked relocation information to historical censuses to determine where people relocated to.

The final dataset is a panel dataset that contains information on people living in the northern region of Alabama with observations for each year between 1930 and 1940 that states whether or not they were convicted for a criminal offense in a given year.

4. Empirical Approach

My main approach in estimating the change in conviction rates per 1000 people uses a nonlinear difference-in-difference model. Specifically, I consider a Poisson regression which uses count data that takes into account a treatment, treated group, and comparison group. The treatment itself is the sudden inflow of TVA relocatees to certain areas in Alabama. The treated group consists of counties that received the influx of people who were forced to relocate from the TVA dam construction projects. My main comparison group consists of counties that would have received an influx of migrants had the dam construction continued downriver of the Tennessee River. Again, it is important to note that the TVA relocated people nearby, mostly within the same county. If the projects would have continued downriver (westward), people would have most likely moved within those same counties, hence serving as my control group in this setting. A visual representation of the treated and comparison counties are shown in Figure 1, along with an alternative comparison group discussed in section 6.

I consider the nonlinear difference-in-differences approach because of the nature of my dataset. Most people were not convicted (0s) and a few were convicted (1s); in general, very few people, compared to a region's population, commit crime and even fewer are caught. To support this style of a low-percentage outcome variable, I turned to a Poisson difference-in-differences framework. To run the Poisson difference-in-differences regression, I converted my outcome variable, conviction rates, into count data which is aggregated over each county for each year per 1000 people. The treated and comparison groups remain the same. My identifying assumption is that conviction rates in treated counties would have progressed similarly to conviction rates in comparison counties had it not been for the sudden influx of TVA relocatees. I show support for the "parallel trends" assumption of similar levels of conviction rates for the treated and comparison group before the influx of relocatees in Figure 2.1 and by race in Figure 2.2

Equation 1 represents my main analysis.

$$log(Y_{it}) = \beta_0 + \beta_1 Treated_i + \beta_2 Post_t + \beta_3 Treated_i * Post_t + \tau_t + \varepsilon_{it} \qquad (1)$$

Where $log(Y_{it})$ represents the log count of convictions for a given county i in a given year $t \in \{1930, 1931, 1932, 1933, 1934, 1935, 1936, 1937, 1938, 1939, 1940\}$. $Treated_i$ takes the value of 1 if the county received an influx of relocatees and 0 otherwise. $Post_t$ represent the years $t \in$ {1933, 1934, 1935, 1936, 1937, 1938, 1939, 1940} after relocation. The interaction $Treated_i * Post_t$ represents the years after each county received the influx of people. The main coefficient of interest is β_3, which represents the expected difference in log count convictions between the treated and comparison group. The error term is represented by ε. The regression uses robust standard errors and is clustered at the county level.

Overall, both treated and comparison groups have 49.4% women and 17.4% and 18.6% Black people in the population respectively. In the pre period, there is an average age of about 23 and 22 for both groups, retained from the 1930s census. As seen in Table 1, there are reported significant differences in the Black population and average age between the treated and comparison group. However, these differences are very small, 1.12 p.p. and 1 year respectively, and thus the treated and comparison groups look very similar to each other.

5. Results

My findings on the overall change in conviction rates are shown in Table 2. Using a Poisson difference-in-differences model, the estimate in column 1 shows the incident rate of convictions after the displacement of TVA relocatees is 1.32 times bigger for areas receiving the influx of people than those who did not receive the influx. This result is in comparison to my main control group which consists of people living downriver of the Tennessee River who would have received an influx of relocatees had the TVA's dam construction continued downriver (westward). The overall finding is also shown graphically in the event study found in Figure 2.1. The main result shows that there was an increase in conviction rates to the areas receiving an influx of people.

To understand how this change in conviction rates affected people differently, I examine effects by race, particularly between Black and White residents. The first two rows in Table 3 represent the Poisson difference-in-differences estimates of conviction rates separately for Black and White residents. I find that both races experienced an increase in conviction rates in the post period. Specifically, the incident rate of convictions for Black people were 1.55 times larger for the treated areas compared to those who didn't receive an influx of people, and were 1.33 times larger for White people in their respective comparison groups. To test whether estimates by race were significantly different, I ran a triple interaction in my Poisson difference-in-differences regressions and found that these are not significantly different from each other as seen in the last row of Table 3.

6. Robustness Check

To test the robustness of results, I consider another alternative comparison group. Shown in Figure 1, the alternative comparison group consists of people living in Alabama counties parallel to the Tennessee River and not receiving an influx of relocatees from the dam construction projects. In Figures A1.1 and A1.2 I show the event studies for my overall and by race findings, which are similar to the original event studies in the main findings. The summary statistics are also similar, Table A1, showing that the treated and parallel comparison groups are similar in characteristics, though the parallel comparison group has fewer Black residents than the treated group. Similarity of results to the main results is shown in multiple tables. In Table 2, the second column shows an incident rate of convictions to be 1.28 times bigger for the impacted areas than non-impacted areas, which is comparable to the incident rate found in column 1. By race, the last two columns in Table 3 show that the incident rate in convictions for both races increased after receiving an influx of people. However, there is no significant difference between races.

For both the downriver and parallel to river comparison groups, I consider a Logit model as an alternative model to the Poisson difference-in-differences main analysis to estimate the effects of the influx of TVA relocatees on the relocated area's conviction rates. In Table A2, the first two columns compare the Poisson estimates to the Logit estimates for the downriver comparison group, while the last two columns compare both models for the parallel comparison group. For ease of interpretation, Poisson results are in their original form as the expected difference in log count between the treated and comparison groups. Taking the natural log of the incident ratio rate from Table 2, ln(1.32), gives us the expected difference in log count estimate. As seen in Table A2, both Poisson and Logit estimates are very similar. The same concept is applied to Table A3, which shows both regression estimates by comparison groups and race. Again, both regressions show very similar estimates when divided into race. For both poisson regressions and logit regressions by race, though there does not consist a consistent significant difference in conviction rates for Black and White people, there is a consistent higher magnitude in conviction rates for Black people versus White. Therefore, results suggest that the effects of receiving an influx of people can potentially have differential effects on groups of people, in this case race.

7. Mechanisms

With limited data regarding TVA's forced displacement, it is difficult to test possible mechanisms driving these findings. While the channels I will discuss do not give a full explanation of findings, it can give us an idea of what may be happening. My first mechanism is derived from the Verne and Schuettler (2021) statement that [population and public expenditure] shocks from a forced displacement on host areas can cause demand and supply shifts in the labor and consumer markets. One may infer that if a sudden influx of people into an area occurs, there can be a high demand for jobs with low supply, hence creating a labor shortage, potentially increasing crime. Such a shortage could explain an increase in conviction rates. To test this, I look at the average of employment of those in the treated group before and after receiving the influx of people. Due to data limitations, I am only able to consider employment levels in the decennial censuses, 1930 and 1940. Table A4 shows that employment levels went up 8 percentage points after receiving the influx of relocatees. Though this increase can be explained by other factors, Harris and Van Leeuwen also find that labor outcomes improved after a forced relocation. These results are suggestive that the increase in conviction rates was not caused by a shortage of labor opportunities.

My second mechanism relates to Alabama's criminal justice system. Specifically, a 1931 case regarding an accusation of rape of two White women by nine African Americans, referred to as the Scottsboro boys, led to a very important milestone in United States' legal system. The case received many retrials, but eventually resulted in another case in 1935, Norris v. Alabama, that stated an exclusion of African Americans on trial juries is unconstitutional, especially when (a) Black person(s) is/are being tried. With this case occurring in the beginning of my studies' post period, a reasonable thought is that if African Americans are now receiving fairer trials regarding jury representation, then there may be a decline in conviction rates for Black people. To test this, I look at conviction rates for Black people in my sample before and after the treatment period. I look at convictions separately by treated and comparison groups. Figure A1.1. shows an increase in conviction rates for the treated group in the post period. When looking at conviction rates for the comparison groups, though both are noisy, there is not a clear decline in conviction rates for either control group which could potentially drive the ATE estimate. Since there is no decline in the conviction rates for Black people in the comparison groups, this roughly suggests that Norris v. Alabama does not explain the increase in conviction rates after receiving an influx of relocatees.

8. Conclusion

A sudden influx of people to specific areas can impact such areas in many ways. Whether the influx is from forced or voluntary displacement, an understanding of its impacts is vital to the welfare of the people in those places. I utilized a historic natural experiment of forced displacement from the Tennessee Valley Authority's relocation program due to their dam construction projects, to examine conviction rates in the host areas in which they moved to. I estimate a causal relationship between an influx of relocatees and an increase in conviction rates in those host areas. I also find evidence of discrepancies in convictions between races, with a significantly higher increase in conviction rates for Black people than White.

As an extension to Harris and Van Leeuwen's (2024) paper on the socioeconomic effects of TVA's forced displacement, we learn that while the TVA's dam construction projects created positive labor outcomes for those displaced, it may have caused some negative impact on those areas hosting the relocatees, specifically with an increase in crime. Further research can examine the long term impacts of crime rates from the TVA's relocation program on the migration of locals, similar to Foote (2015)[4].

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[4] Foote (2015) examines the effects of crime on population changes. He finds an increase in crime rates causes individuals to leave metropolitan areas; a larger effect for White residents than Black.

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Tables and Figures

Figure 1. Treatment and control counties

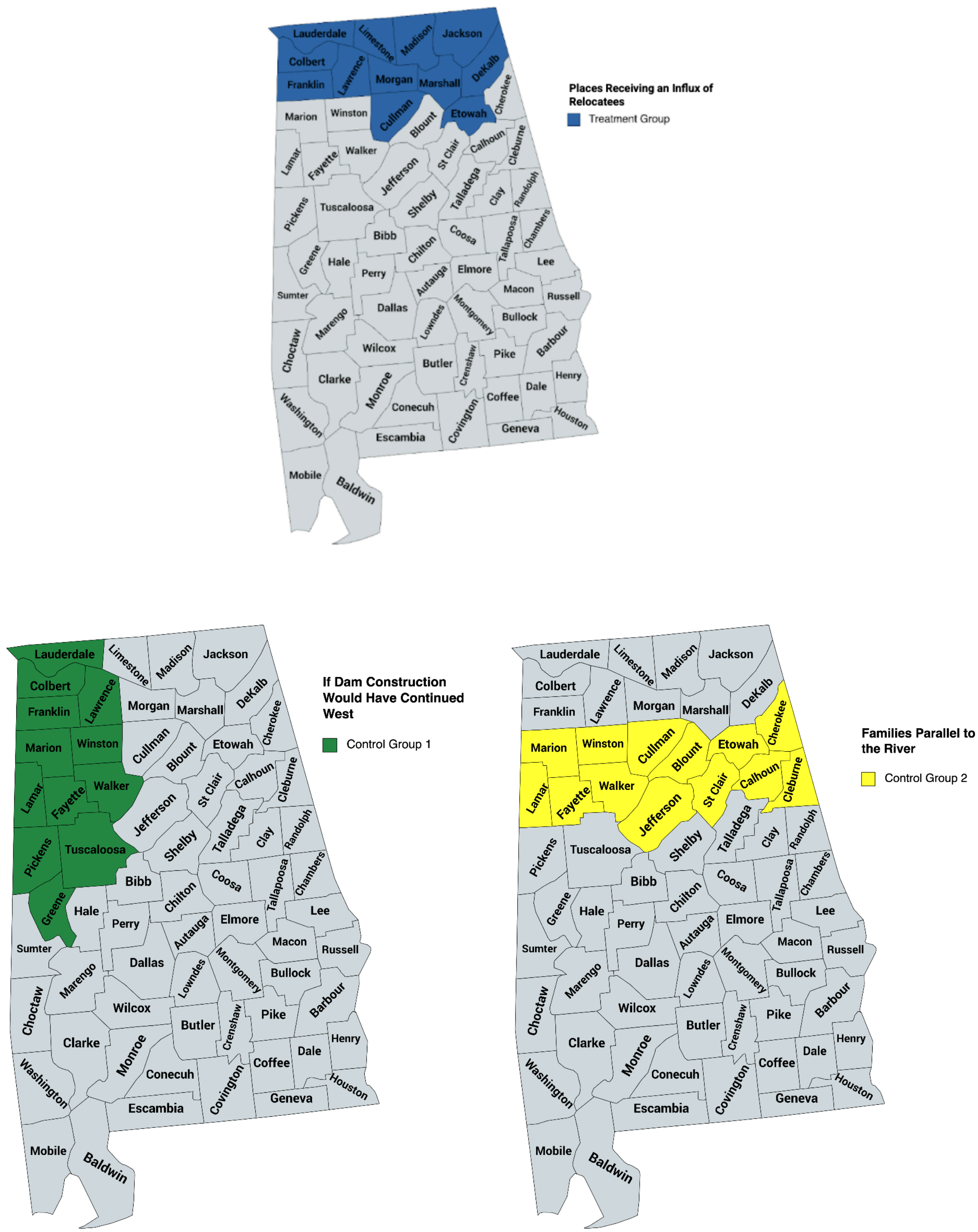


Figure 2.1. Event study estimates of conviction rates

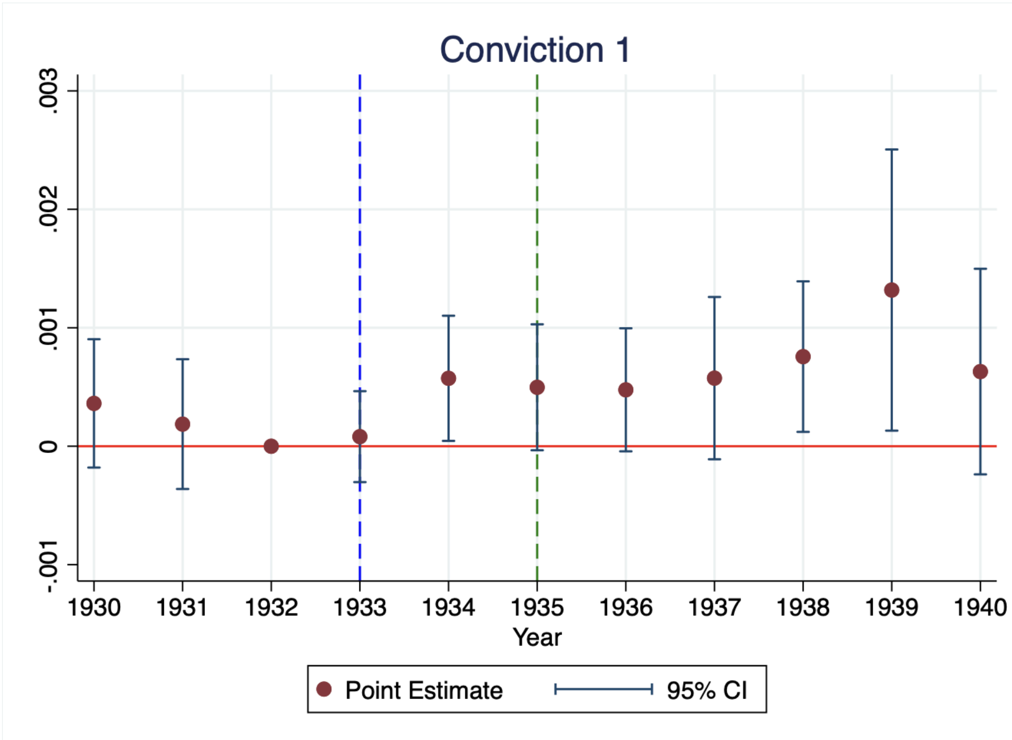
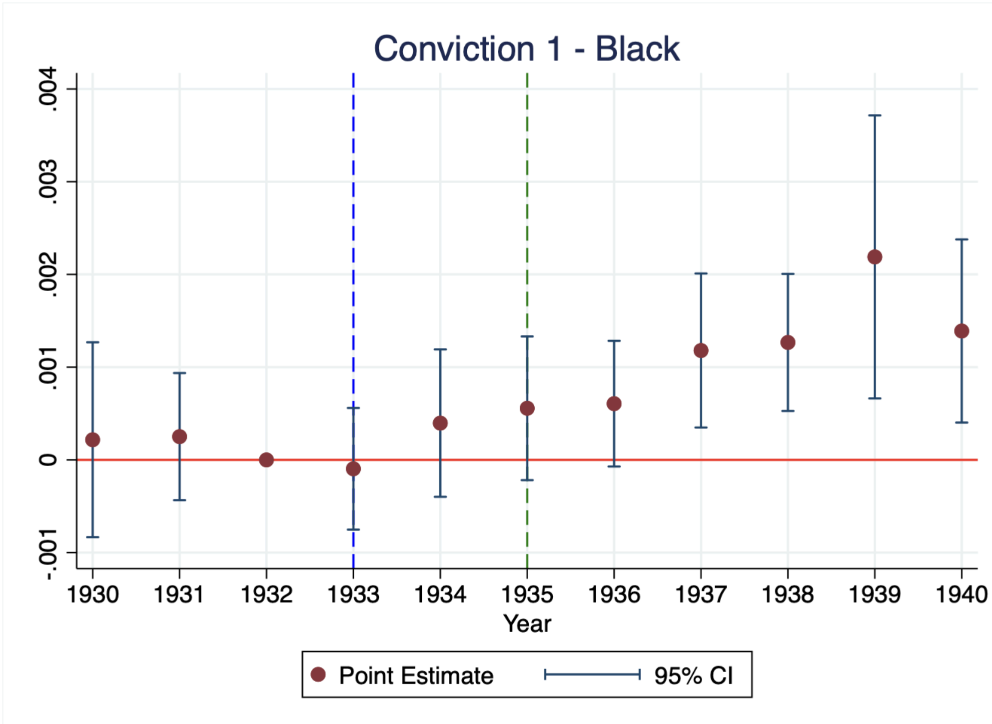


Figure 2.2. Event study estimates of conviction rates, by race


Conviction 1 - Black
-.001
0
.001
.002
.003
.004
1930
1931
1932
1933
1934
1935
1936
1937
1938
1939
1940
Year
Point Estimate
95% CI

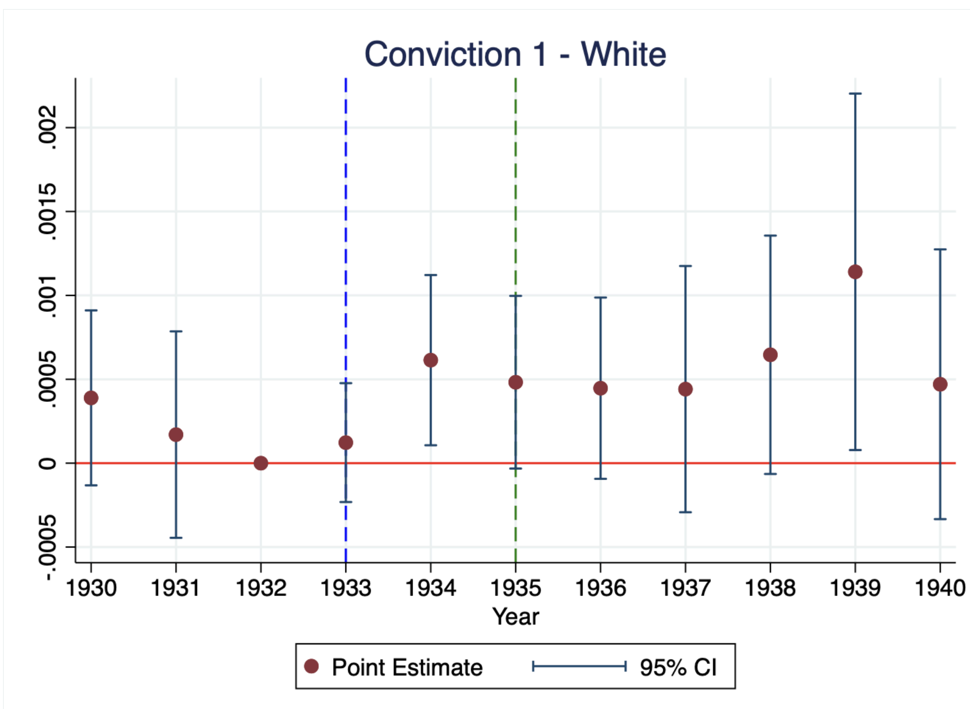

Conviction 1 - White
-.0005
0
.0005
.001
.0015
.002
1930
1931
1932
1933
1934
1935
1936
1937
1938
1939
1940
Year
Point Estimate
95% CI

Table 1. Summary statistics on Treated and Comparison groups

	Treated	Downriver	Difference
Female	0.494	0.494	0.000
	[0.500]	[0.500]	(0.001)
Black	0.174	0.186	-0.012***
	[0.379]	[0.389]	(0.001)
Age	22.65	21.639	1.011***
	[17.094]	[17.333]	(0.031)
Observations	6,011,907	1,428,856	

Notes: Summary statistics are separated by treated group, those receiving the influx of people, and downriver comparison group, those who would have received the influx of people if the dam construction projects continued downward of the Tennessee River. Standard deviations are in brackets, standard errors are in parentheses. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Table 2. Effects of an influx of TVA relocatees on locals' conviction rates

	(1)	(2)
Incident-Rate Ratios	Conviction	Conviction
Treat	1.0102	1.0765
	(0.1684)	(0.1626)
Post	0.9008	0.9418
	(0.0711)	(0.0635)
Treat*Post	1.3200**	1.2836**
	(0.1747)	(0.1329)
Observations	275	275
Mean	1.087	1.137

Notes: The first column represents the ATE between the treated and the downriver comparison group while the second column represents the ATE between the treated and parallel comparison group. Conviction rates are per 1000 people in each county. The Poisson regressions use count data for the 25 counties in the sample per year, 11, hence the observation count is 275. The models cluster on the 1930 counties. Estimates and robust standard errors, in parentheses, are displayed in exponential form. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Table 3. Effects of an influx of TVA relocatees on locals' conviction rates, by race

VARIABLES	(1) Black	(1) White	(2) Black	(2) White
Treat	0.9027	1.0436	0.8958	1.1295
	(0.2192)	(0.1724)	(0.1747)	(0.1706)
Post	1.0017	0.8702*	0.9048	0.9363
	(0.2389)	(0.0665)	(0.1277)	(0.0673)
Treat*Post	1.5522	1.3265**	1.7927**	1.2547**
	(0.5192)	(0.1762)	(0.4799)	(0.1374)
Observations	275	275	275	275
Mean	1.403	1.043	1.467	1.095
Sig. Difference?	No	No	No	No

Note: The first two columns represent Black and White conviction rates from the treated group and downriver comparison group (1). The last two columns represent Black and White conviction rates from the treated group and the parallel comparison group (2). Estimates are measured as incident rate ratios per 1000 people from a Poisson regression and are clustered on 1930 counties. Sig. Difference shows if there is a significant difference in estimates between Black and White conviction rates for each treated-control comparison. Robust standard errors in parentheses *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Appendix

Figure A1.1 Event study estimates of conviction rates, Treated and Parallel comparison groups

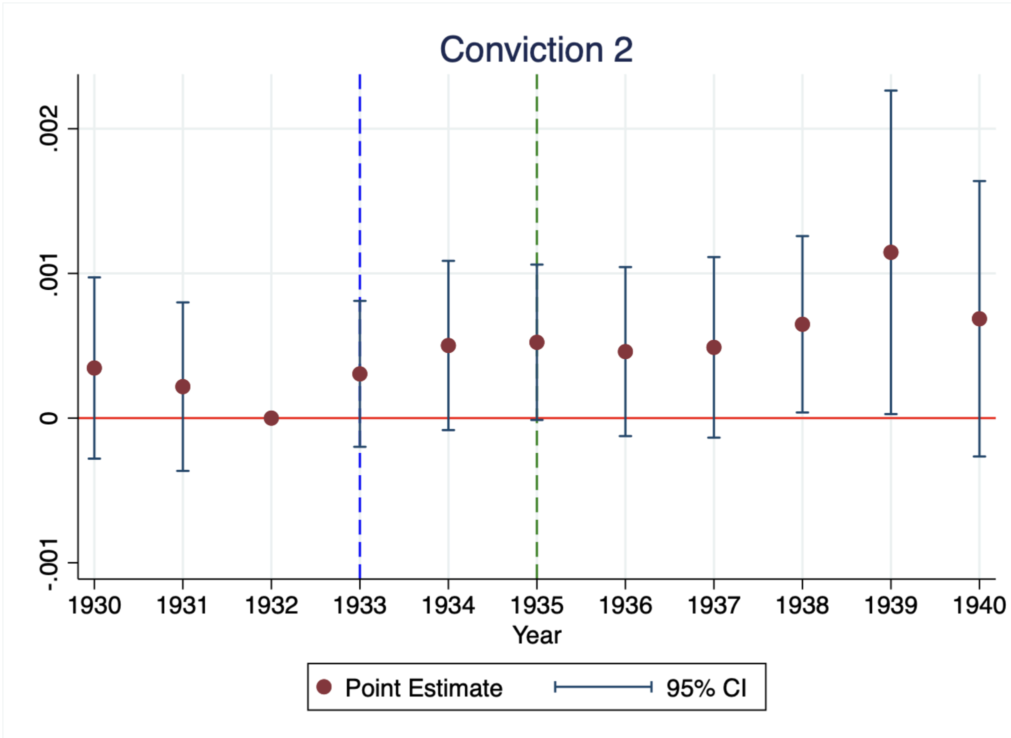
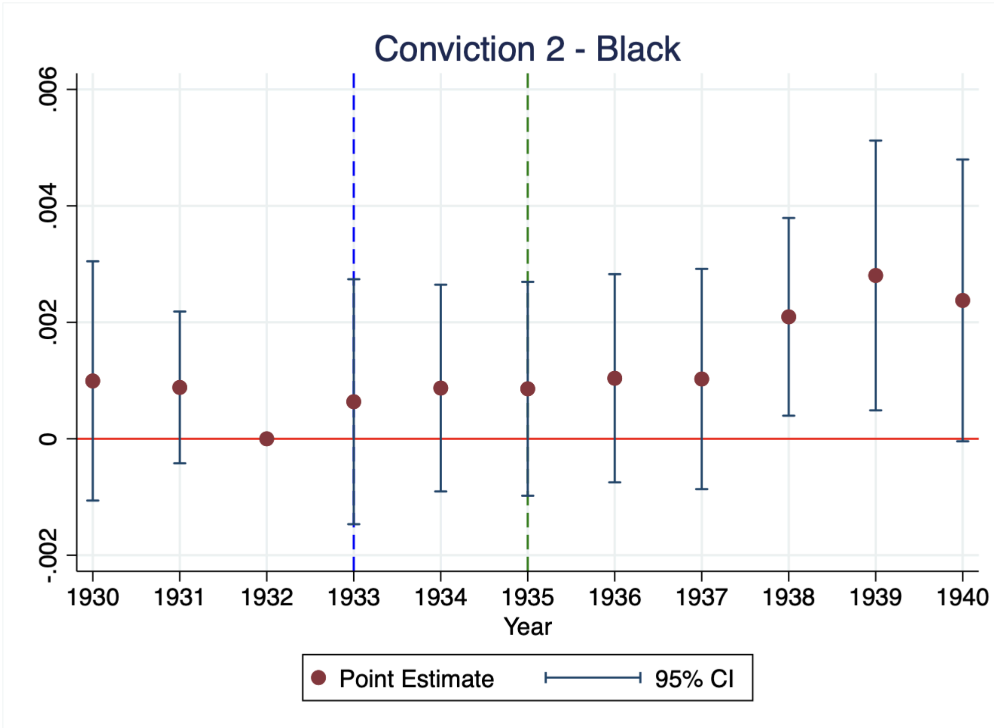


Figure A1.2. Event study estimates of conviction rates, by race, Treated and Parallel comparison groups



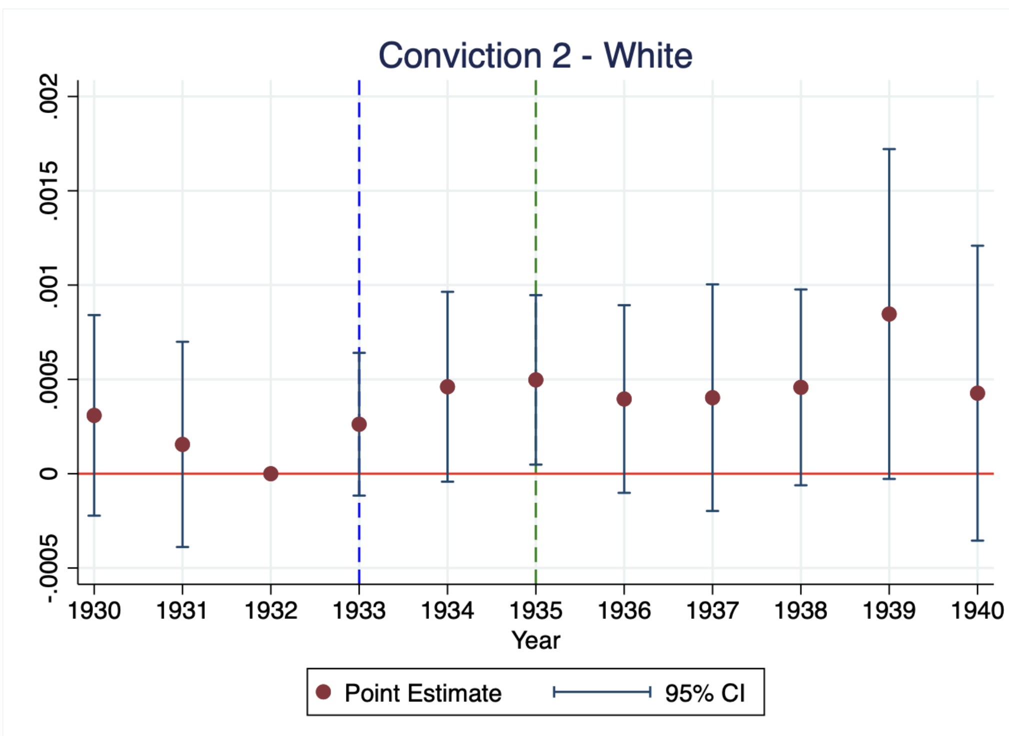


Figure A2.1. Number of convictions for Black period across time, treated group

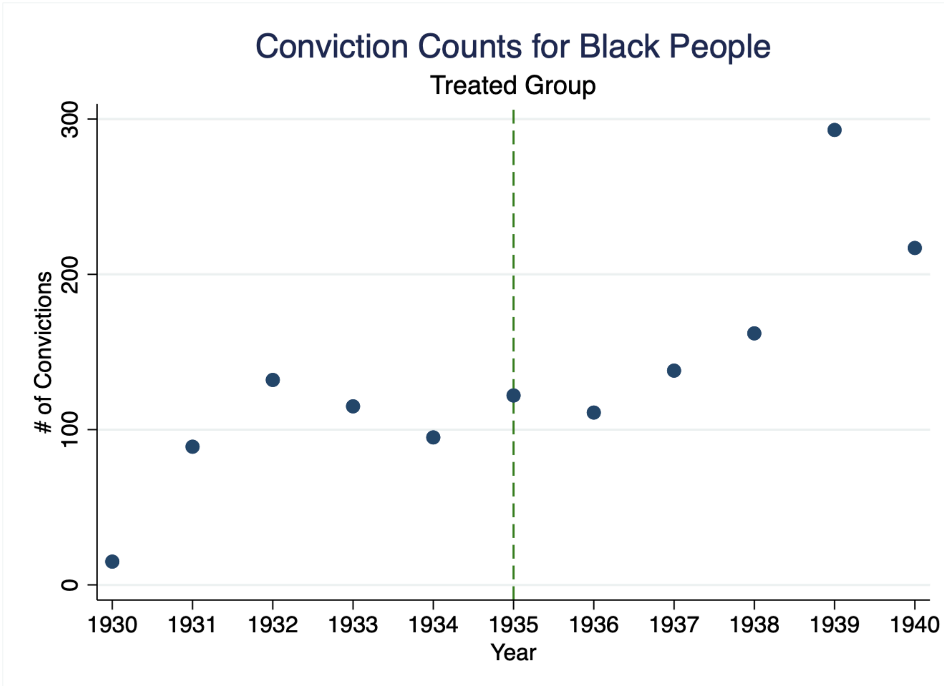
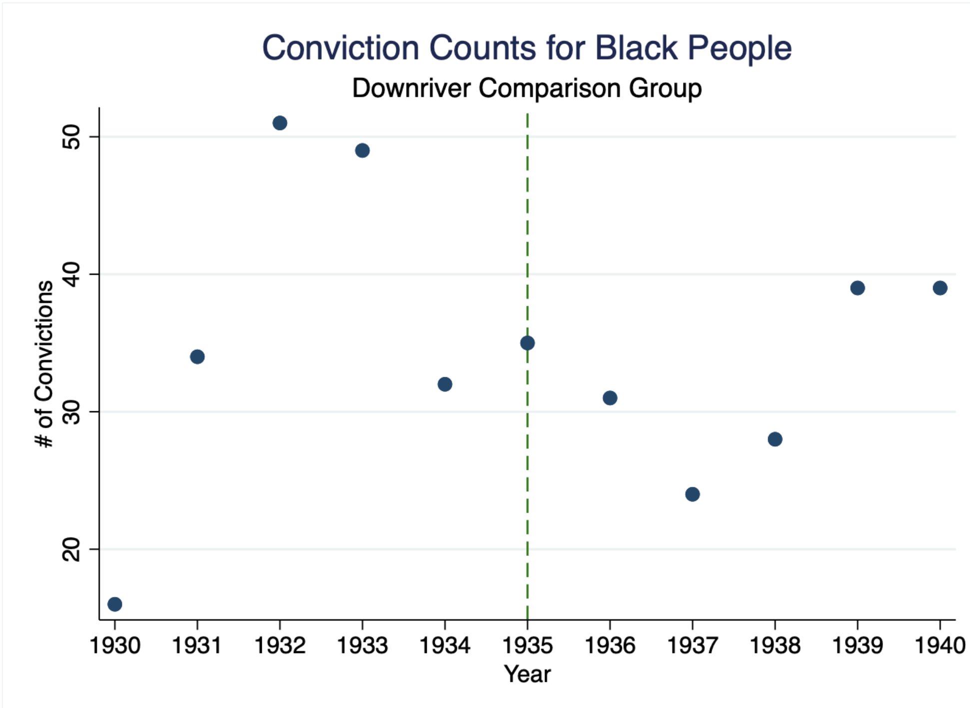


Table A2.2 Number of convictions for Black period across time, downriver and parallel comparison groups



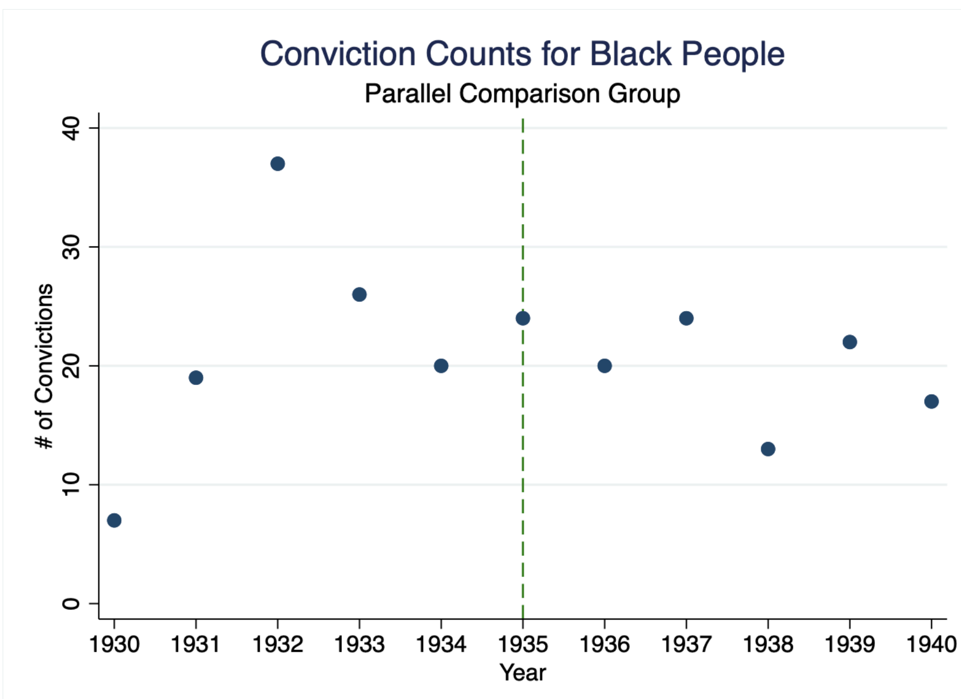


Table A1. Summary statistics on Treated and Comparison groups

	Treated	Parallel	Difference
Female	0.494	0.496	-0.002**
	[0.500]	[0.500]	(0.001)
Black	0.174	0.096	0.078***
	[0.379]	[0.295]	(0.001)
Age	22.65	21.212	1.438***
	[17.094]	[17.082]	(0.030)
Observations	6,011,907	1,541,276	

Notes: Summary statistics are separated by treated group, those receiving the influx of people, and parallel comparison group, those living parallel of the Tennessee River who did not receive the influx of people. Standard deviations are in brackets, standard errors are in parentheses. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Table A2. Effects of an influx of TVA relocatees on locals' conviction rates, Poisson and Logit model comparisons

	(1)	(1)	(2)	(2)
VARIABLES	Poisson	Logit	Poisson	Logit
Treated	0.0101	-0.1259	0.0737	-0.0416
	(0.1667)	(0.1434)	(0.1510)	(0.1423)
Post	-0.1045	-0.0914	-0.0600	-0.0567
	(0.0790)	(0.0690)	(0.0675)	(0.0905)
Treat*Post	0.2776**	0.3133***	0.2497**	0.2616**
	(0.1323)	(0.1041)	(0.1035)	(0.1165)
Observations	275	5,712,201	275	5,712,201
Mean	1.087	5.03e-05	1.137	5.39e-05

Notes: The first two columns represent ATE between the treated and the downriver comparison group while the last two columns represent the ATE between the treated and parallel comparison group. Conviction rates are per 1000 people. The Poisson regressions use count data for the 26 counties in the sample per year, 11, hence the observation count is 286. Logit regressions use the panel data of individuals per year. Both models cluster on the 1930 counties. The Poisson estimates are measured as the expected difference in log count between the treated and comparison groups from a Poisson regression and the Logit estimates are from a logit regression. Robust standard errors in parentheses. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Table A3. Effects of an influx of TVA relocatees on locals' conviction rates, by race, Poisson and Logit model comparisons

Conviction Rates	(1) Black	(1) White	(2) Black	(2) White
Poisson				
Treat	-0.1023	0.0427	-0.1100	0.1218
	(0.2428)	(0.1652)	(0.1950)	(0.1510)
Post	0.0017	-0.1390*	-0.1000	-0.0659
	(0.2384)	(0.0764)	(0.1412)	(0.0719)
Treat*Post	0.4397	0.2826**	0.5837**	0.2269**
	(0.3345)	(0.1328)	(0.2677)	(0.1095)
Observations	275	275	275	275
Mean	1.403	1.043	1.467	1.095
Sig. Difference?	No	No	No	No
Logit				
Treat	-0.0080	-0.1238	0.0390	-0.0267
	(0.2880)	(0.1282)	(0.2757)	(0.1213)
Post	-0.0276	-0.1079	-0.1018	-0.0449
	(0.1168)	(0.0694)	(0.0689)	(0.0996)
Treat*Post	0.4300***	0.2990***	0.4845***	0.2185*
	(0.1489)	(0.1079)	(0.1081)	(0.1252)
Observations	700,810	5,011,325	700,810	5,011,325
Mean	0.000528	5.50e-05	0.000715	5.75e-05
Sig. Difference?	No	No	Yes	Yes

Note: The first two columns represent Black and White conviction rates from the treated group and downriver comparison group (1). The last two columns represent Black and White conviction rates from the treated group and the parallel comparison group (2). Conviction rates are per 1000 people. In the first panel, estimates are measured as the expected difference in log count between the treated and comparison groups from a Poisson regression and are clustered on 1930 counties. In the second panel, estimates are from a logit regression and are clustered on 1930 counties. Sig. Difference shows if there is a significant difference in estimates between Black and White conviction rates for each treated-control comparison. Robust standard errors in parentheses*** $p<0.01$, ** $p<0.05$, * $p<0.1$

Table A4. Employment Change between 1930 and 1940

Rate of Employment	1930	1940
%	30.89	38.37
# Employed	166,885	186,093
Observations	*540,256*	*485,003*

Notes: The rate of employment is calculated for those in the treated areas that have not been convicted, before and after receiving an influx of relocatees. Employment status considers those employed, not employed, not in the labor force, and those with no response.